A Short History of Printing

The invention of movable type changed how knowledge travelled. Before it, every book was copied by hand, and a **single** mistake could pass from copy to copy for centuries. Printers could now set a page once and print it *hundreds of times*, which made books cheaper and far more consistent.

Early Presses

Early presses were made of wood and worked like a wine press. A skilled team could print a few hundred sheets a day. Ink was mixed by hand from soot and varnish, and paper was dampened before printing so that it took the ink evenly.

- Gutenberg Bible, about 1455
- Soncino Hebrew Bible, 1488
- Aldine editions of the classics, from 1495

Why It Mattered

Printed books spread new ideas quickly. Scholars in different cities could finally refer to the same page of the same edition, and errors could be corrected in the next printing rather than

copied forward forever. This simple change is one reason the period is called a revolution.

Steps in Setting a Page

1. Pick each letter from the type case.
2. Lock the lines into a frame called a chase.
3. Ink the type and pull the press.

“What the printing press did for books, the scanner can do again for old books.”

Modern readers can reach the same books in seconds. Water has the formula H_2O, and Einstein wrote $E = mc^2$; even such small details should survive conversion.

1 Dates are approximate and vary between sources.